

Memo

To: Dr. Derek G. Ross, Dr. Stewart Whittemore, and Dr. Susan Youngblood

From: V. Jasey Herrington

Re: Multilingual Survey Meta-Analysis

Date: January 17th, 2026

Audience and Purpose

The Multi-Lingual Survey was developed in ENGL 7080: Document Design as a client-based project focused on designing an accessible, multilingual digital survey for Metropolitan Community College's adult education program in Omaha, Nebraska. The primary audience consisted of ESOL adult learners, many of them having recently completed the college's GED program. A secondary audience included program administrators and accrediting bodies who rely on post-program data for assessment and funding purposes. The purpose of the survey was to collect the required data while reducing linguistic, cultural, and emotional barriers that often limit or prohibit participation among adult learners, especially non-native English speakers.

I served as a co-designer and client liaison for this project, contributing to needs assessment, design planning, translation and localization decisions, usability testing, and revision. Early in this project, my partner and I proposed an instructor training manual to our client. However, after discussion with the client(s) they revealed that the most pressing need for their program was a post-completion data collection tool. This shift reinforced a core principle of technical communication: the most effective documents emerge from user needs.

Goals and Editing Process

The project goals were shaped by practical constraints and my scholarly interest in language acquisition, linguistic equality, and accessibility. A primary function of this survey was to

acknowledge respondents' varying level of English proficiency without positioning multilingualism as a deficit to learning. Because adult language learners often have to navigate high-stakes institutional communication while still acquiring English, the survey needed to support differing levels of comprehension, reduce cognitive load and avoid unnecessary complex phrasing. A second goal was to increase participation by fostering trust, particularly because this survey required participants to provide sensitive financial and personal information related to employment, living, and financial outcomes. These goals influenced our decisions about question sequencing, tone, and translation.

Our design process followed the Planned Rapid Document Development (PRDD) model described by Kimball and Hawkins (2008), emphasizing iterative editing and client feedback. We used Jotform's multilingual function to support translation and localization. This allowed respondents to participate in the survey using their preferred language, helping ensure comprehension and credibility. Usability testing with current ESOL students revealed the pain points in current communication and early drafts of the survey. These findings prompted revisions that simplified phrasing, clarified intent and purpose of the survey, and aligned the survey closer to that of our respondents' cultural realities. Instructor feedback further supported revisions that balanced accessibility and design principles.

Theories

Several theoretical frameworks informed this work, but it remained grounded in applied practice. User-centered and participatory design principles guided our emphasis on testing with actual users rather than assumed audiences. It was extremely helpful that my editing partner had a personal and professional connection to the program and could provide further insight into student needs. Additionally, scholarship on ethics and social justice in technical communication (Walton, Moore, & Jones, 2019) frame linguistic access as an equity issue rather than a mere convenience. My own interest in language acquisition further shaped my role in the document by centering the importance of designing documents that support meaning-making for adult learners.

This project also expands on the traditional definitions of document design. While the final deliverable emphasized interface and digital interaction rather than static visual composition, its legitimacy emerged through client negotiation, usability testing, and ethical responsiveness.

Works Cited

- Kimball, M. A., & Hawkins, A. R. (2008). Planned rapid document development: A model for creating usable documentation under tight constraints. *Technical Communication*, 55(3), 297–307.
- Walton, R., Moore, K. R., & Jones, N. N. (2019). Technical communication after the social justice turn: Building coalitions for action. *Technical Communication*, 66(4), 277–295.